“Major Defense Partner,” and the signing of a Communications, Compatibility and Security Agreement allows the United States to transfer secure communications and data equipment to India and to share real-time data with the Indian military over secure channels. In 2015, India and the United States articulated a Joint Strategic Vision for Asia-Pacific and the Indian Ocean, and the first-ever US–India 2+2 ministerial-level dialogue held in 2018 was an important milestone. In his chapter, Pant identifies the sum of these initiatives and agreements as a sign of moderate alignment between India and the United States. However, the agreements India has signed with the United States in recent years would enable a relatively smooth upgrade of their military relationship, if deemed necessary.

India is also strengthening its partnership with Japan. Mukherjee, in his contribution to this volume, argues that India and Japan would not be able to effectively balance against China, and India engaging Japan should thus be interpreted as a long-term effort to strengthen its economic basis rather than being part of an external balancing policy towards China. Still, as Japan is the most important alliance partner of the United States in Asia, India’s close relationship with Japan, and its engagement with the United States, Japan, and Australia in their Quadrilateral Initiative, is a signal to Beijing that India shares certain perspectives on security and stability in the region with these countries.

Despite Russia moving closer to China than ever before, India’s enduring relationship with Russia is not a signal of India moving closer to China. Both Raghavan and Stobdan present arguments for why New Delhi needs to retain its strong partnership with Moscow. Russia is a significant provider of weapons platforms to India, their energy cooperation has great potential, and, by being an alternative partner for Russia in Asia, New Delhi wants to avoid Russia drifting into a deeper dependence on China and a closer China–Russia axis.